

bank? Or called your health insurance provider? Sucks. Sucks. And double-sucks. Customer service today has become a lost art. Our expectation of service with businesses has become so pathetic that we've become numbed to expect nothing but disinterest.

Down the block from my home, there is a strip mall with a corner restaurant that changes ownership every six months. Since I've lived in the neighborhood, four restaurants have opened and four have closed. While I can't comment on the first three failures, and I can on the last. When I dined at the latest incarnation of the restaurant, the food was decent but the service was deplorable. Drinks went unfilled. The silverware was dingy. The waitress was arrogant, as if our patronage was an inconvenience. After leaving, I thought, "That place ain't gonna last," and sure enough, a few months later the sign went up: "For Lease."

While bad customer service is frustrating while playing our consumer role, it gives us entrepreneurs a great opportunity. *Where customer service lacks unearths great opportunity.* You see, the beauty of expectation is that it works in reverse. While complaints of expectation are about the violation of expectations negatively, customer service that s-u-c-s is about violating expectations positively.

EXCHANGE "SUCKS" FOR "S-U-C-S"

You can explode your business into the stratosphere by deploying a customer service strategy that exceeds expectations: I call it sucs, or "Superior Unexpected Customer Service."

We all expect a certain level of suckage when it comes to customer service. This is an advantage for Fastlaners. For example, if I discover a \$10,000 fraudulent withdrawal on my bank statement, my first instinct is to freak out. My second instinct is to call the bank to resolve the problem. At that point, my brain immediately creates a smorgasbord of expectations for the bank call. Here is my "expectation profile," or what I expect:

- I expect to hear a recorded message or an automated attendant.
- I expect to press a never-ending menu of buttons: press 1 for this, press 2 for that, press 3 for something else.
- I expect to be shuttled from one person to the next.
- I expect to speak with someone not fluent in English named "Steve" but sounding more like a Pradeep or Sanjay.

These are my expectations. No doubt, my customer service expectation isn't that favorable. My bank, and hundreds of other banks like it, gets away with crappy service because it is now our expectation. However, let's flip the scenario on its rear. What if I call the bank and instead of the voicemail rat-maze, my call is immediately answered by an English-speaking person. No voice mail, no press 1,